

Rukhsana Kauser THE AXE EFFECT



PARVEEN NEGI/www.indiatodayimages.com

There's nothing extraordinary about this 19-year-old girl from Shahdra Sharif in the Rajouri district of Jammu and Kashmir. But Rukhsana Kauser displayed rare courage when she axed to death an armed Lashkar-e-Toiba (LeT) commander and then, along with her 18-year-old brother, snatched guns from two other militants and opened fire, wounding one and forcing them to flee. "I had never touched a rifle before this, let alone fired one. But I had seen heroes firing in films. Somehow I gathered courage and fired and fought till dead-tired," she said. The terrorists wanted to seek revenge and hold the family hostage for refusing to give shelter to LeT militants.

Geethu Anna Jose HEAD AND SHOULDERS

For this 6 ft-2 inch girl from Kerala, playing basketball was a natural progression. And she has earned high marks already. The Indian team may have been minnows against powerhouses like Japan and Korea at the 2009 FIBA Asian Women's Cup but Geethu Anna Jose emerged top scorer with 132 points and was declared the most valuable player (MVP) of the tournament. She was voted MVP in the 2006 Commonwealth Games too. The 24-year-old is also the first Indian women basketball player to turn professional and play in the Australian league.

(SHASHAN PAUL/www.indiatodayimages.com)



Pankaj Advani BOY WONDER

This was one title that Pankaj Advani sorely missed in his cabinet. This year he beat nine times champion Mike Russell to win the elusive World Professional Billiards Championship. He is the second, and youngest, Indian to win this coveted prize. With this win, Advani now holds the unique



record of being the current World Professional Billiards champion, International Billiards & Snooker Federation World Billiards champion, Asian Games Billiards champion, Asian Billiards champion and the National Billiards champion. And he's all of 24.

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